

11. Emotional Expression

Observable, positively framed language for documenting how children express a range of emotions.

All emotions are valid. Document the observable signs of emotion without labeling the child as 'dramatic,' 'moody,' 'oversensitive,' or 'a crier.' Describe what you see and hear.

Signs of Joy & Excitement		
smiled broadly	laughed aloud	clapped hands
jumped up and down	ran with arms out	said '___' with a raised voice
sought eye contact while laughing	giggled repeatedly during ___	expressed enthusiasm by ___
shared the moment with a peer or adult		

Signs of Frustration or Upset		
cried for ___ minutes	whimpered	said 'no' repeatedly
pushed materials away	walked away from the activity	lay on the floor without moving
covered face with hands	stomped feet	slammed materials on the table
said '___' (exact words used)	made a sound described as ___	required ___ minutes before re-engaging

Signs of Calm & Contentment		
engaged quietly with materials for ___ minutes	hummed or sang quietly to themselves	smiled occasionally during the activity
sat relaxed with open body posture	responded to conversation in a measured tone	worked steadily without visible distress
appeared focused and at ease		

Signs of Worry or Uncertainty		
stood at the edge of the group before joining	watched the activity for ___ minutes before participating	looked toward the door at drop-off for ___ minutes
asked 'where is my mom/dad?' ___ times	clung to adult at transition	held a comfort object throughout ___
needed adult reassurance before attempting new task	hesitated before entering a new space	covered mouth or twisted clothing during ___

Signs of Pride & Confidence		
held up work and said 'look'	smiled and repeated the action after succeeding	said 'I did it!'
sought adult acknowledgment after completing task	tried again after an initial unsuccessful attempt	showed work to a peer
independently selected a challenge-level task		